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# Liminal spaces: A review of the art in entrepreneurship and the entrepreneurship in art

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**Abstract** Arts entrepreneurship is still in its early stages as an emerging field of academic and scholarly inquiry at the intersection of art(s) and entrepreneurship. As such its boundaries and scope are still being negotiated. In this article, we examine entrepreneurship's recent treatment of art (and vice versa) to explore and describe the hidden assumptions evident in each parent discipline's characterization of the "other." To do so, we identify and review 98 articles in entrepreneurship journals that address the field of art(s), and 165 articles in art journals that address the field of entrepreneurship. We then narratively analyze the breadth of approaches toward art(s) in entrepreneurship scholarship (and vice versa) and their relative frequency. This narrative analysis permits an examination of key peripheries in the overlap between art and entrepreneurship's implicit conceptualizations of one another, specifically the importance of dissent and liminality. We close by identifying opportunities for further enriching arts entrepreneurship research and practice.

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## 1 Introduction

### 1.1 Overview

Academic and practitioner interest in the intersection of art and entrepreneurship is increasing, as shown by the growth in relevant research published in scholarly outlets (Barry 2011; Gangi 2015; Burton 2003; Preece 2011; Stinchfield et al. 2013; Woronkowicz and Noonan 2019). But—as is the case with many nascent academic fields—boundaries, definitions, scope, and goals of arts entrepreneurship are in flux.

Recent attempts at describing and delineating the relevant domain of arts entrepreneurship have included an examination of "a range of perspectives on the boundaries of 'the arts and culture sector'" (Essig 2015b, p. 2); a systematic literature review for the purpose of differentiating "arts," "creative," and "cultural" entrepreneurship (Hausmann and Heinze 2016); and a comparison to other related academic fields (Essig 2017b). These efforts provide tremendous value and structure for defining the core of the arts entrepreneurship field, but their predominant focus on *explicit* integration of art and entrepreneurship neglects the equally important *implicit* integration, the taken-for-granted connections between art and entrepreneurship.

Our novel approach to investigating the implicit intersection of art and entrepreneurship provides a solid foundation for generating new perspectives on arts entrepreneurship. We ask three related research questions: How does the field of entrepreneurship implicitly conceptualize art? How does the arts field implicitly conceptualize entrepreneurship? And how do (or should) these conceptualizations inform the integration of art and entrepreneurship in the arts entrepreneurship field? We start with a comprehensive literature review of entrepreneurship's perspective on art and the arts' perspective on entrepreneurship. Then, drawing from our narrative summary and synthesis, we highlight knowledge gaps and misconceptions in and about the arts entrepreneurship field.

### 1.2 Background and motivation

As arts entrepreneurship seeks to define itself (Beckman and Essig 2012; Roberts 2012; Gangi 2017; Toscher 2019), it looks frequently to the field of entrepreneurship. Arts entrepreneurship imports theories from more "mainstream" entrepreneurship such as effectuation (Bissonnette and Arcand 2018; Gangi 2017), bricolage (Di Domenico et al. 2010), and emancipation (Callander 2019). It addresses topics that are familiar to entrepreneurship scholars, such as self-employment (Roberts 2012; Essig 2015a, b; Gangi 2017), venture creation (Essig 2015a, b; Newton 2017; Hanson 2019), and economic growth (Seman 2015; Vakharia 2016; Rubião 2018).

But despite this apparent surface-level consonance between arts entrepreneurship and mainstream entrepreneurship research, there also exists potential for conflict. Researchers and practitioners in the arts entrepreneurship field are sometimes forced to negotiate what they perceive as difficult gaps between the aims, processes, and practices of art and of entrepreneurship. For example, one perceived source of conflict is the 1980s neoliberal dismantling of social safety nets that many associate with entrepreneurship rhetoric (Bonin-Rodriguez 2014) and identify as conflicting with "commons-based" efforts in the arts sector to counter "unjust disparities" (Mathew and Carl 2013, p. 14). Additionally, entrepreneurship is frequently framed as inseparable from business, a reductive perspective that limits the ability of scholars to effectively embrace the full scope and potential of the arts entrepreneurship field (French 2018). The development of a unifying framework in the arts entrepreneurship field is slowed somewhat by disagreement about the goals of arts entrepreneurship as a practice and a subject of scholarly inquiry. Some call for an open-ended approach that allows for the young discipline to respond to unforeseen developments in the field; others insist that standardization of process and practice is essential if the discipline wishes to mature (Beckman and Essig 2012). Both sides of the argument vie to sustain arts entrepreneurship, but at the heart of this divergence is a fundamental tension between plurality and hegemony.

How can the field resolve political and operational differences? Should a field oriented toward innovation even attempt a consensus-based resolution? And if resolution proves elusive, what strategies can be deployed to support cohesion, if not uniformity? Our proposed efforts to survey the fields of art and entrepreneurship are a step toward identifying an emergent consensus around definitions and conceptions of arts entrepreneurship. As arts entrepreneurship seeks self-definition, it might glean some insights from both its more established siblings.

## 2 Methodology

Given our research questions, a literature review methodology is most appropriate. Prior work has identified several typologies of literature reviews, including systematic, narrative, critical, and conceptual (Thomé et al. 2016). The most appropriate for our purposes is narrative review, which covers studies that are both directly and indirectly related to the selected topic. Like Vasquez's (Vazquez 2018) review of family business ethics, we combine a structured search process with a narrative review of the relevant literature. The structured search ensures that we have broadly surveyed the potential literature, but the narrative (rather than systematic) review is necessary because a fully systematic review (for example, of "arts entrepreneurship" definitions) would exclude the indirect or accidental treatment at the interstices of arts entrepreneurship and both its parent fields.[1] Because of the unique nature of our research focus, we conduct two parallel, comparable searches to identify peer-reviewed academic articles (1) in entrepreneurship journals that meaningfully address "art" or "arts," and (2) in arts journals that meaningfully address

[1] For example, an entrepreneurship scholar using, describing, or interacting with the arts may not intend to contribute or even be aware of arts entrepreneurship as an independent scholarly domain, but would still fall within the target boundaries for our search.

"entrepreneurship."[2] Without claiming either list is completely exhaustive, we feel confident these papers provide a broad and rich representation of arts studies engaging with entrepreneurship, and vice versa.

### 2.1 The art in entrepreneurship

To ensure broad coverage of relevant journals, we chose as our main search parameter seventeen entrepreneurship-focused research journals.[3] We searched these journals using both Proquest and Google Scholar databases. Because our search objective was to capture articles that substantially engage with art[4] from the perspective of entrepreneurship scholarship, so the terms we used suggest a relatively inclusive definition of art and included the following: aesthetic, art, arts, artist, artistic, choreograph*, creative industr*, creative process*, creative writ*, creatives, danc*, improvis*, music*, orchestra, paint*, photog*, printmak*, studio, theat*. Following standard practice in literature surveys (e.g., David and Han 2004; Newbert 2007), we limited the initial search to article titles and abstracts to capture those that address the topic as a central objective of their scholarly contribution.[5] We focused on the time period of 2000 to 2019, which corresponds with several of the important legitimating historical occurrences in the arts entrepreneurship field's origins.[6] This search yielded 176 initial articles.

We followed a multistage coding process to screen out less relevant papers (Armstrong et al. 2012; Armstrong et al. 2012; McKelvie et al. 2019). We reviewed each paper in detail and excluded from our sample papers that used relevant terms in general or common ways that are tangential to arts entrepreneurship. Common terms used in this way include "improvisation" and "creation," for example; the phrase "new business creation" may in fact have little to do with art or creativity. In one instance, we excluded a paper in which the author's first name was Art. We also excluded articles if they did not engage conceptually with art (such as, for example, a pedagogical article contrasting business and art students). We include book reviews and teaching-oriented case studies (e.g., Lemmetyinen 2019; Anderson et al. 2014), if they provide a prolonged engagement with or use of art-related concepts. After these exclusions, we were left with a sample of 98 publications from 2001 to 2019.[7]

### 2.2 The entrepreneurship in art

We also performed a parallel search in peer-reviewed arts publications. To ensure broad coverage of relevant journals, we selected both leading general arts journals, as well as field journals within the arts.[8] Because our search objective was to capture articles that substantially engage with entrepreneurship, broadly defined,[9] from the perspective of arts scholarship, our search terms included the following: entreprene*, self-employ*, and value creat*. Following standard practice in literature

[2] Note that our search excludes arts management journals to keep the focus on implicit conceptualizations in the "home" disciplines of art and entrepreneurship, and away from more explicit treatments of arts entrepreneurship. For similar reasons, we exclude nonprofit management and nonprofit marketing journals because although relevant, they triangulate/overlap with arts entrepreneurship scholarship from a different direction, rather than reflecting the attitude of one "home" scholarly discipline about the other.

[3] We focused on those rated 2 or higher on the Association of Business Schools' Academic Journal Guide (ABS, 2018). Not every journal returned search results, for example, the topical focus of Venture Capital: An International Journal of Entrepreneurial Finance decreased its potential for overlap with our target areas. For a list of those we drew from, see Table 1.

[4] To limit scope, we confine our focus to the visual and performing arts.

[5] We considered and explored conducting a more comprehensive search of each article, encompassing articles' full text, but such a search resulted in an unmanageable number of articles, which would have required a narrower set of search terms and would have been at odds with the purpose of our study.

[6] Specifically, the Beckman and Essig (2012) point to Eastman School of Music's Arts Leadership program (1997), UC Boulder's Entrepreneurship Center for Music (2001), and Maryland Institute College of Art's Community Arts Project (1999) as examples of legitimation for arts entrepreneurship.

[7] See online appendices for a complete list. We also used the references section of these articles to perform a backwards citation search, scanning the titles and abstracts of more than 1500 cited articles to identify potentially relevant pieces, then examining each in-depth to see if it added contextual or conceptual novelty to our sample. Although this exhaustive backward citation exercise identified several potentially relevant articles, all of them fit within the existing categories in our typology, suggesting that we had reached theoretical saturation.

[8] To generate our list of art journals, we started with Google Scholar Metrics and examined four subcategories: (1) drama and theater arts; (2) film; (3) visual arts, (4) music and musicology. In these four categories, we selected journals in the top 5 within their category OR with an H-5 index 10 or above, de-emphasizing journals that are education or pedagogy-focused. We supplemented this initial list by examining backward and forward citations of relevant arts entrepreneurship literature and consulting experts in arts entrepreneurship. For a list of journals in our sample, see Table 3.

[9] We adopt the following definition of entrepreneurship: "The field of entrepreneurship is the scholarly examination of how, by whom, and with what effects opportunities to create future goods and services are discovered, evaluated and exploited" (Shane and Venkataraman, 2000).

**Table 1** Entrepreneurship articles by journal

| Journal | Number of articles |
|---|---|
| Entrepreneurship and Regional Development | 14 |
| Entrepreneurship Research Journal | 2 |
| Entrepreneurship Theory and Practice | 15 |
| Family Business Review | 2 |
| International Journal of Entrepreneurial Behaviour & Research | 7 |
| International Journal of Entrepreneurship | 4 |
| International Journal of Entrepreneurship and Innovation | 7 |
| International Small Business Journal | 7 |
| Journal of Business Venturing | 6 |
| Journal of Small Business and Enterprise Development | 7 |
| Journal of Small Business Management | 3 |

surveys (e.g., David and Han 2004; Rawhouser et al. 2019), we limited the initial search to article titles and abstracts to capture those that address the topic as a central objective of their scholarly contribution. As before, we focused on articles published post-2000. This initial search returned only 51 potential articles for inclusion, so we expanded our search within these journals to encompass those that use the search terms in the body of the article, and not just the abstract. This supplementary search returned an additional 274 articles.

As before, we followed a multistage coding process to screen out less relevant papers—those that used search terms in ways that are shallow or tangential to arts entrepreneurship (Table 2). For example, a cinema scholar may briefly mention an important historical figure who happens to be an entrepreneur (Vasudevan 2010). After these exclusions, we were left with a sample of 165 publications from 2001 to 2019.[10]

## 3 Results and narrative summary

### 3.1 The art in entrepreneurship

Perhaps unsurprisingly, given the recent emergence of arts entrepreneurship as a field of scholarly inquiry, more than three quarters of the articles in our

[10] See online supplemental materials for a complete list.

**Table 2** Art as depicted in entrepreneurship scholarship

| Dimension | Description | Illustrative examples |
|---|---|---|
| Industry | The arts as a commercial sector | Art is referred to as "goods" (Pret et al. 2016) or "cultural--symbolic products" Lange (2011)<br>Sold through industries that mediate "between the creators of unique works of art and those who buy them" (Le Breton-Miller and Miller 2015) |
| Domain | The arts as a sphere of activity or knowledge | Addressing disciplines as "arts and literature" (Abreu et al. 2016) or "arts and sciences" (Riot 2019), or activities of art schools (Fritsch and Aamoucke 2013) |
| Tool | The arts as instrument of socio-political change, economic growth, community-building, therapy, or an artifact for historical study | Art supports economic growth (Steyaert, 2011) and community development (Di Domenico et al. 2010)<br>Art serves as a tool for analysis (Clarke and Holt 2017; Smith, 2015), a source of provocation (Olive-Tomas and Harmeling 2020), and a platform for dissidence (Dodd 2014) |
| Metaphor | The arts as figurative; arts as lexical substitution | References descriptively "painting the full picture" (Pret et al. 2016) or metaphorically describes entrepreneurial processes using a "weaving metaphor" (Johannisson 2011) |
| Medium | The arts as literal; direct use of artmaking processes | Poetry: "Entrepreneurship is a phenomenon, not a theory, To always look for some causal explanation makes me weary, I know scholarship seeks to answer the "why?," But I am most interested in "what," "how," and the nature of "try." (Gartner 2008)<br>Utilization of drawing as a vehicle for metaphoric analysis of entrepreneurs (Clarke and Holt 2017). |

**Table 3** Arts articles by journal

| Journal | Number of articles |
|---|---|
| Art Journal | 19 |
| Cinema Journal | 51 |
| Critical Studies in Television | 2 |
| Theatre Topics | 14 |
| Theatre Journal | 35 |
| Journal of Film & Video | 18 |
| Dance Research Journal | 8 |
| Popular Music & Society | 22 |

entrepreneurship sample were published in 2010 or later, reflecting significant recent growth and momentum for research at the intersection of arts and entrepreneurship (Fig. 1). The most prevalent three journal outlets in our sample were *Small Business Economics*, *Entrepreneurship Theory and Practice*, and *Entrepreneurship and Regional Development*.

As we reviewed our entrepreneurship sample, we discovered a wide variety of approaches to studying arts, and group these into five categories.[11] (1) We use the term "*Industry*" to describe those that address art in commercial contexts. (2) We use the term "*Domain*" to describe those that address art as a sphere of non-commercial activity or knowledge. (3) We use "*Tool*" to describe those that address art as an instrument, or a means to an end. (4) We use "*Metaphor*" to describe those that use art as rhetorical shorthand to substitute for other concepts. (5) We use the term *"Medium*" to describe those forms of scholarship that produce or address engagement with artmaking.

### *3.1.1 Dimensions and variations*

Almost 60% of the entrepreneurship articles reference the arts as *industry*, or existing within commercial contexts. Gafni et al. (2019) frame the arts as a cultural industry subsector; Pret et al. (2016) address cultural capital and goods; Greenman (2013) situates a fine art graduate within commercial art markets; Kuhn and Galloway (2015) study the effect of networking on small arts business success; Lange (2011) focuses on the "culturepreneur"—"an urban protagonist who possesses the ability to mediate between and interpret the areas of culture and service provision" (260); Conroy and Weiler identify artists as "high human capital" (2016, 407).

Just over one-half (56%) of the entrepreneurship articles surveyed here reference the arts as *domain*. The arts are conceptualized as a sphere of knowledge, or as a professional arts-based practice somewhat indifferent to the commercial realm (Table 4). The arts are classified as disciplines within programs of study (Anderson et al. 2014), art schools (Pret et al. 2016; Fritsch and Aamoucke 2013), and universities (Abreu et al. 2016; Fini et al. 2017; Meoli and Vismara 2016; Steyaert 2011).

Twenty-six percent of the entrepreneurship articles reference art as *tool*, or a means to an end. The arts bring attention to and facilitate relief of food insecurity (Anderson et al. 2014); engage a variety of stakeholders in urban regeneration (Bobadilla et al. 2019); and provide context to "inform us of deeper sensibilities and strategies in the nature of entrepreneurship" (Gartner 2007, p621). The study of arts techniques develops agility in "unstructured or uncertain situations" (Balachandra 2019, p61), while the "symbolic type of knowledge" generated by arts institutions "could be important for the emergence of innovative new businesses" (Fritsch and Aamoucke 2013, 870). The arts serve as a source of provocation (Olive-Tomas and Harmeling 2020); a platform for dissidence (Dodd 2014); a vehicle for institutional critique (Dodd 2014); a historical record (Riot 2019); an agent of local revitalization (Vestrum 2014).

In 11% of the articles, the arts are employed as—or for creation of—*metaphor*, with clear intention to familiarize the reader with an issue by referencing a practice of artmaking that falls outside the domain of entrepreneurship. Some serve up a pun: "painting the full picture" (Pret et al. 2016); others allude to entrepreneurial capacity: "This paper . . . paints entrepreneurs as master storytellers" (Pelly 2016, 488). Less superficially, arguing the strength of a practice-theory approach to entrepreneurship, Johannisson (2011) writes "the organizing context provides both the core of the warp and the main bulk of the weft in entrepreneuring as a weaving process" (144).

[11] As with any narrative synthesis or qualitative analysis, the categories we identify are not representations of "objective" reality but are subjective interpretations of the reviewed literature. Nevertheless, in our analyses we were careful to iterate between our qualitative datapoints and our categories, adjusting as necessary to incorporate new information or to better accommodate the breadth of related concepts (Cummings et al. 2020).

**Table 4** Entrepreneurship as depicted in arts scholarship

| Dimension | Description | Illustrative examples |
|---|---|---|
| Profit: Applause | Entrepreneurship as a non-critical instrument for generating financial return in exchange for arts products or services, | Praising the combination of "imagination and entrepreneurial spirit" (Leja 2011, 66) |
| Profit: Ambivalence | Entrepreneurship as a potentially compromising or problematized instrument for generating financial return in exchange for arts products or services, or a profit-generation | Highlighting tensions between critical and commercial success (Bennett 2005) Linking entrepreneurship to both employment and labor exploitation (Arrighi 2017); Punk rock musicians advocate for an alternate economy that resists corporate consolidation, cultural hegemony, and wealth accumulation (Faris 2004; Goshert 2000; Nehring 2007) |
| Meaning: Creation | Entrepreneurship conceptualized within artwork or exercised in the process of artmaking | Exploring the cautionary tale of a "Southern entrepreneurial family destroyed by greed" (Smalec 2011, 444) or the "Yankee entrepreneur on the make" (Werry 2005, 370) |
| Meaning: Sustenance | Entrepreneurship as a means of sustaining art production for its own sake | Encouraging artists to focus on how they can "exploit business knowledge and business practices to create opportunities for creative practice" (Essig 2009, 124) |
| Re-making: Renewal | Entrepreneurship as a process for reorganizing an existing institution or organization. | The nexus of arts, public policy, and entrepreneurship as a driver of effective campus responses to institutional change (Watson 2010) |
| Re-making: Reform | Entrepreneurship as a process for reforming an existing institution or organization. | Radical art movements that eschew external validation and engage art activism and socially engaged art as vehicles "to bypass institutions of representative democracy and to directly create noncapitalist forms of association" (Leger 2011, 51). An entrepreneurial stance that critiques and resists privatization and corporatization of higher education culture which "turn[s] the university into a 'factory' and professors into businessmen" (Bryan-Wilson 2012, 77) |

Another 5% position art as a *medium* for entrepreneurship research and analysis, for institutional critique, and for entrepreneurial experimentation. Clarke and Holt (2017) employ drawing for "metaphoric analysis" of entrepreneurial identity (476), while Smith (2015) considers "the entrepreneur as poet" (450) and asks whether "poetry [is] a legitimate linguistic medium for expressing entrepreneurial experiences" (451). Dodd (2014) frames punk rock as an "an alternative countercultural meaning-frame of enterprise" (166); an artistic medium that "explicitly confronts the assumptions and practices of market capitalism" (167). Lüthy and Steyaert (2019) study artists who implicitly conflate art and enterprise as disruptive and generative mediums for world-making. Under *medium*, entrepreneurship scholars open the door to the possibility that entrepreneurship can practice art.

Singular conceptualizations are uncommon in the literature. In most of the articles, conceptualization of art as industry, domain, and/or tool overlaps. For instance, Le Breton-Miller and Miller (2015) differentiate art (a "human activity the product of which is targeted to the emotions . . . and the senses") and arts-related industries ("mediators between the creators of unique works of art and those who buy them") (p. 1353–54). Olive-Tomas and Harmeling (2020) identify a type of artist-provocateur who, within the larger arts economy, effectuates system change within both academic and

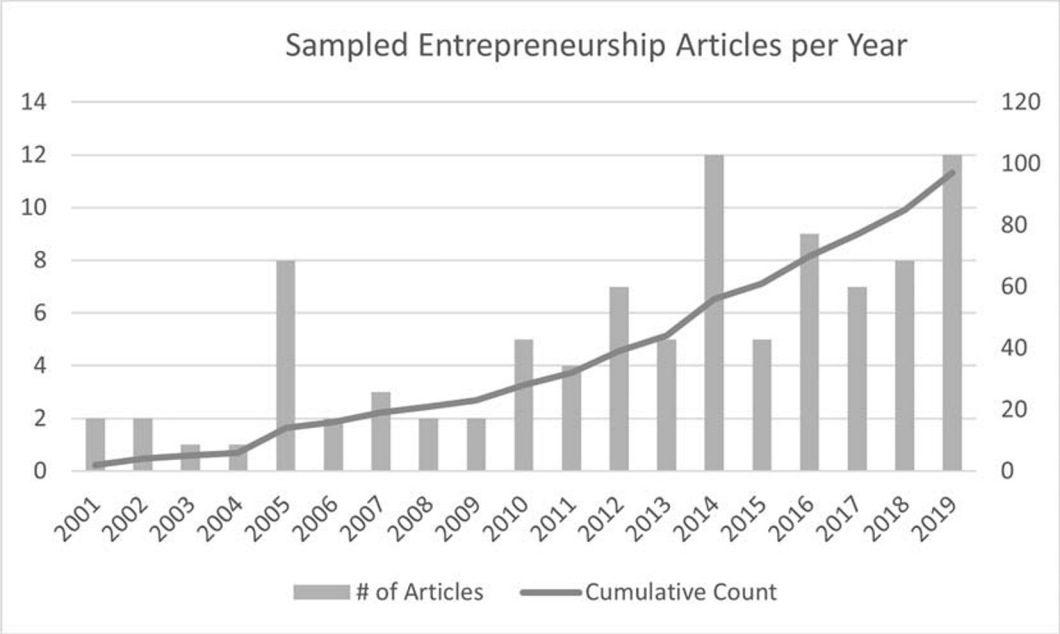


**Fig. 1** Sampled entrepreneurship articles per year

commercial aspects of the art world. Riot (2019) refers to global arts entrepreneurs, but also to a painting as an artifact and a "product of situated volition or intention" (p. 7). Altogether, eight articles engage three or more of the five dimensions; we address several of these in the discussion below.

### 3.2 The entrepreneurship in art

Unlike the "art in entrepreneurship" sample, which is more heavily weighted toward the end of our sample period (about ¾ post-2010), our papers in this search are more evenly split across our 20-year period, with approximately half published in the 2000s, and half in the 2010s. Perhaps this consistency reflects within the mainstream arts scholarship a relatively better awareness of entrepreneurship than vice versa (Fig. 2). The most prevalent two journal outlets in our sample were *Cinema Journal* and *Theatre Journal*, with 51 and 35 articles, respectively.

As we reviewed our arts sample, we discovered a wide variety of approaches to studying entrepreneurship in the context of art, and group these into three main categories and six subcategories described in more detail below. 1) We use "*Profit-making*" to describe those that address entrepreneurship as an instrument for generating financial return in exchange for arts products or services, through either non-critical (applause) or ambivalent (ambivalence) lenses. 2) We use the term "*Meaning-making*"[12] to describe those that address entrepreneurship as a means of sustaining art production for its own sake *(sustenance*), and entrepreneurship conceptualized within artwork (*creation*). 3) We use the term "*Re-making*" to describe those that address entrepreneurship as a process for reorganizing (*renewal*) or reforming (*reform*) of an existing institution or organization. We describe each of these in turn below.

#### *3.2.1 Dimensions and variations*

Almost 2/3 (64%) of the articles draw a connection between entrepreneurship and *profit-making*. Within this category, most (63%) deliver uncritical praise for "optimistic pragmatism" (Burns 2008, 19); shrewd opportunism (Kelly 2002; Schultz 2015; Young 2015); and "entrepreneurial imagination" (Quinn 2010, 97). The entrepreneur is a commercial artist (Dass 2009, 77); a creative commercial outsider (Nowell 2011a; Poppe 2014; Wang 2013); and a risk taker (Schaefer 2002). With less fanfare, but no less approval, self-

[12] Our approach is differentiated from some other uses of "meaning-making" within the entrepreneurship literature, which "depicts "meaning-making" associated with entrepreneurial opportunities as an ongoing process that unfolds through continuous interactions between actors and artifacts" (Nambisan 2016).

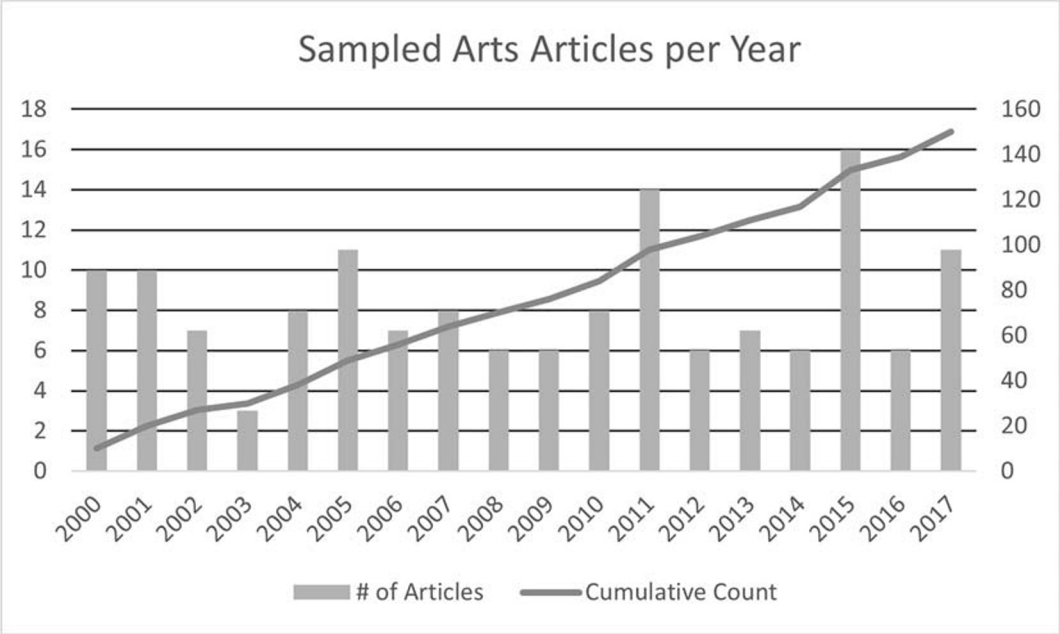


**Fig. 2** Sampled arts articles per year

employment (King 2002) and a generic equivalence between entrepreneurship and business (Kattelman 2010; Owczarski 2012) are identified and touted as entrepreneurial. Profit is the measure of success. This category we refer to as "applause."

Just over one-third (37%) of the articles within the category of *profit-making* reference entrepreneurship as a double-edged sword. An equivalence between entrepreneurship and commercialization points to tensions between critical and commercial success. Of the commercial expansion of the Hong Kong Lesbian and Gay Film Festival, Qin (2019) writes

> The film festival ultimately became a commercialized LGBT cultural event rather than prioritizing the construction of a tightly knit *tongzhi* community. Even though the commercialized film festival is irregularly criticized by local *tongzhi* activists, its commercialization is useful in increasing the *tongzhi* community's visibility (42).

Entrepreneurship is linked simultaneously to employment and labor exploitation (Arrighi 2017); commercialization of fan fiction is problematized when not driven by its predominantly female fan base (Busse 2015; De Kosnik 2009). Gindt (2013), in his profile of publisher and theatre producer Lars Schmidt, writes "Without downplaying Schmidt's explicit agenda of wanting to make theatre lucrative, I wish to contrast his brazenly commercial mentality with his willingness to take risks and support less profitable work" (Gindt 2013, 36). Profit is problematic. This category we refer to as "ambivalence."

Under "ambivalence," punk rock musicians advocate for an alternate economy that resists corporate consolidation, cultural hegemony, and wealth accumulation (Faris 2004; Goshert 2000; Nehring 2007); digital pirates—consumers and sellers alike—violate copyright law as an exercise in agency that challenges the anti-entrepreneurial concentration of power and property (Fox 2004). Dancers are "targets of the apparatuses of twenty-first century capitalism" (Ramsay 2018, 100) and frequently classified as members of the "precariat" (Quinlan 2017; Reynoso 2019; Schuh 2019) who are nonetheless celebrated for their flexibility and ingenuity in disseminating a time-based and intangible product (Blades 2019; Kloetzel 2017).

Almost 40% (39%) of the articles draw a connection between entrepreneurship and *meaning-making*. Within this category, 80% reference the symbolic representation of entrepreneurship within an artwork. We call this type of meaning-making "creation." In "creation," the value associated with entrepreneurship is first and foremost symbolic, and often is embedded in a direct critique of neoliberalism, which conceptualizes wealth and poverty as interdependent (Hughes, 3).

Entrepreneurship-specific content challenges dominant socio-economic political structures, specifically neoliberal values of privatization, individualism, and deregulation, and their implied assault on individual and collective well-being. The impulse to locate "the precarity of life in the neoliberal age" (Hughes 2015, 3) and entrepreneurship as a specter of destruction is illustrated in the depiction of a "Southern entrepreneurial family destroyed by greed" (Smalec 2011, 444); the "Yankee entrepreneur on the make" (Werry 2005, 370); the "evil entrepreneur involved in the global trafficking of human body parts" (Peacock 2012, 42); and "exploitive entrepreneurs and hucksters" understood to be "unsavory human beings" who "prey" on people (Schleier 2012, 34). An indirect indictment of neoliberal precarity can be found in the glorification of the rapper as a criminal entrepreneur: "Trapped in America's economical caste system, rap lyricists tell us the only way they can break free from poverty is to operate outside the system, and outside the law" (Hess 2005, p. 187).

The remaining articles (20%) under *meaning-making* reference entrepreneurship, specifically venture formation, as a means of sustaining the production and delivery of artwork not for the purpose of deriving profit from arts-based products and services, but to advance and sustain artmaking. This we refer to as "sustenance." Under "sustenance," the entrepreneur is a pioneer who creates space for marginalized creatives (Peterson 2011); or, in the case of television writers, a free agent within the corporate entertainment structure who negotiates for creative independence and the right to work horizontally across markets rather than vertically within a single company (Heuman 2013; Kraszewski 2006). In this portion of the literature, Essig (2009) argues that the arts need to stop treating entrepreneurship as a "dirty word" and entrepreneurial artists as "sell out[s]"; instead, she encourages artists to focus on how they can "exploit business knowledge and business practices to create opportunities for creative practice" (Essig 2009, p. 124).

Fifteen percent of the articles draw a connection between entrepreneurship and *re-making*, that is, the restructuring of existing organizations or institutions. Within this category, 33% engage entrepreneurship in intrapreneurial terms: leadership seeks to maintain or grow the financial health of an organization as it encounters changing market demands and shifting policy environments. Miller (2016) calls on university educators to meet "seismic upheaval in the academy" with "a revisioning of higher education that is not afraid to take risks" (4). Referencing the Creative Campus movement, Watson (2010) cites the nexus of arts, public policy, and entrepreneurship as key in forming an institutional response to "the challenges of an uncertain and rapidly changing world" (p. 181). Accordingly, the "development of human creative capabilities" and "programs of innovation and campus-wide competition" purportedly serve to jettison the arts as agents of change both on- and off-campus (182). This we refer to as "renewal." It is a conceptualization of entrepreneurship that dramatically expands in the arts management literature, which seeks not the formation of ventures so much as the reorganization or redirection of established entities.

Sixty-seven percent of the articles under *re-making* target entrepreneurship as an instrument of neoliberal economic policy, and they seek to dismantle its negative impact on social welfare, freedom of speech, and labor policies that disadvantage the many for the benefit of the few. Ironically, the attack on organizations or institutions that this portion of the literature articulates is itself at times a form of entrepreneurial action. For instance, Leger (2011) examines art activism and socially engaged art as vehicles "to bypass institutions of representative democracy and to directly create noncapitalist forms of association" (p. 51). The majority in this subsection locates the focus of its critique within higher education. Bryan-Wilson (2012) traces resistance to privatization and the corporatization of higher education culture which "turn[s] the university into a 'factory' and professors into businessmen" (p. 77) to the free speech movement of the mid-1960s. Bousquet (2006) examines managerial solidarity within the university's administrative ranks and its systematic undermining of faculty agency and governance. Cole (2015) excoriates business-speak permeating campus culture: "Everyone is interested in accountability. But responsibility? Not so much. Today, we have "value propositions," but little reflection on values" (p. 9). Griffin (2013) protests the neoliberal academic "mandate for self-management" (145), while Nagler (2015) labels the contingent educator a "wage-earning body" (81) and calls for resistance to productivity. This we refer to as "reform."

## 4 Discussion

Recall the motivation for our study. In our introductory section, we summarized how recent efforts to describe

and situate the arts entrepreneurship field have been oriented toward the explicit definitions and boundary conditions of the emerging field. But a focus on the explicit self-definition of the hybrid field overlooks the potential contributions of implicit perspectives. To address this shortcoming, we ask three research questions and explore them via narrative literature review. How does the field of entrepreneurship implicitly conceptualize art? How does the arts field implicitly conceptualize entrepreneurship? And how do (or should) these conceptualizations inform the integration of art and entrepreneurship in the arts entrepreneurship field? Our results section answered the first two research questions, and we turn now to the third by revisiting key issues and big-picture questions in the arts entrepreneurship field, before turning to a discussion of how our *implicit*-focused findings can contribute to a greater depth and breadth, rigor, and relevance, of arts entrepreneurship scholarly inquiry and practice.

### 4.1 Review of key issues, big-picture questions, and explicit conceptualizations

The academic literature in the emergent field of arts entrepreneurship expresses three primary motivations: (1) to grow the financial well-being of arts organizations, (2) to strengthen artists' entrepreneurial skills, and (3) to define the field. There is also a strong interest in policymaking and creative placemaking[13] because of their relationship to the integration of the arts in urban development projects. Additional (though less common) areas of arts entrepreneurship scholarly concern are institutional critique (White 2019) and artmaking itself (Callander 2019). Given these motivations, the typical contexts for this literature are the cultural industries (Bissonnette and Arcand 2018; Essig 2015a, b; Hausmann and Heinze 2016; Whitaker 2019), the nonprofit sector (Arroyo 2017; Borrup 2017; Heidelberg 2019), and higher education (Beckman and Essig 2012; White 2013; Manjon and Guo 2015).

These explicit concerns and contexts overlap with the entrepreneurship literature's dominant conceptualization of the arts as a *context* for commercialization, and the arts literature's dominant conceptualization of entrepreneurship as a *process* by which art is commercialized. But conceptualization of the arts as a commercial sector and of entrepreneurship as an instrument for generating financial return are only a part of the picture.

The goal of our survey is to shed light on how the disciplines of entrepreneurship and art implicitly conceptualize one another, to outline gaps and misconceptions, and to provide a near-term agenda for further discovery at the intersection of these two important disciplines. To that end, we take a closer look at key peripheries in the overlap between art and entrepreneurship's implicit conceptualizations of one another.

### 4.2 Dissent and liminality

The focus on self-definition in the emerging field of arts entrepreneurship exposes a fundamental tension between consolidation and expansion, what Essig refers to as "premature adoption of core competencies" in the search for cohesion and legitimacy, which might have the impact of limiting the nascent discipline's capacity to engage "the breadth of artistic specializations, technologies, and geographies it potentially encompasses" (2012, p. 2). Our results above contribute to exploration of this fundamental tension not only in core arts entrepreneurship but also in the implicit conceptualization at the boundaries of arts and entrepreneurship.

In addition to papers in our sample that adopt a limited "traditionalist" view of the other field, such as the manifold entrepreneurship papers treating art as just another industry or context, we also find a significant portion of the entrepreneurship literature conceptualizes art as an instrument or *tool* of provocation and a challenge to the cultural, socio-economic, or political status quo (Olive-Tomas and Harmeling 2020; Lüthy and Steyaert 2019; Dodd 2014). Similarly, although the most common treatment of entrepreneurship in our arts papers was as a celebrated, profit-making vehicle within existing commercial structures, a substantial portion of the arts literature conceptualizes entrepreneurship as a vehicle for resistance to market-driven hegemonic tendencies (Faris 2004; Goshert 2000; Nehring 2007; Fox 2004, 459; Lewis 2000; Newman 2009). Our results suggest that for both the disciplines of art and entrepreneurship, in addition to using the intersection to operate more effectively within existing taken-for-granted assumptions and power

[13] The National Endowment for the Arts defines creative placemaking as an activity in which "partners from public, private, non-profit, and community sectors strategically shape the physical and social character of a neighborhood, town, city, or region around arts and cultural activities" (Markusen and Gadwa 2010, p. 3).

structures, each also recognizes the other as a potential mechanism for dissent.

In particular, both sets of literature offer a vision of artists and entrepreneurs operating in the margins, in some cases out of necessity, but in others as a strategy for horizontal resistance to vertical consolidation of both economic power and cultural pluralities. These margins are characterized by some degree of liminality or boundary-spanning. In the entrepreneurship literature, Dodd (2014) identifies punk rock as a genre that "combines cultural production and independent economic action" (166). Similarly, Lüthy and Steyaert (2019) point to a conflation of art and enterprise in their profile of Atelier für Sonderaufgaben (Afs) whose "entrepreneurial experimentation" rejects popular preconceptions of how the worlds of art and entrepreneurship should operate, pursuing instead the idea "that art should be located amid society rather than in museum spaces and that [the experiment] has not only an artistic but also an entrepreneurial value". Both Dodd and Lüthy and Steyaert present entrepreneurship as an artistic medium; it is perhaps unsurprising that the articles present a multi-dimensional treatment of art, engaging four of the five dimensions defined in the survey.

The arts literature captures similar boundary-spanning in the work of street performer and activist filmmaker Reverend Billy who deliberately crosses the line between private and public spaces to commit cultural acts of trespass that defy commercial culture and attempt to "pry open possibilities for participation in a 'marketplace of ideas'" (Whedbee 2019, p. 39). ATSA (Action Terroriste Socialement Acceptable), a socially engaged art collective and part of a larger radical art movement that "no longer looks to the field of art production for the validation of meaning" (Leger 2011, p. 51), stages disruptive interventions in public spaces to protest capitalist conditions that "individualize social problems" (p. 63).[14] Whedbee and Leger present artworks that operate entrepreneurially; our *creation* and *reform* categories overlap.

Liminality and its dissolution of boundaries between art and entrepreneurship is not without peril. In the arts literature, Siegelbaum (2013) and Zimmerman (2017) articulate a potential cost. Siegelbaum presents *social sculpture*, an accentuated form of socially engaged art that arose in the late 1970s and was built on challenging "norms and static hierarchies" (52) and its originator, visual artist Joseph Beuys, as merging institutional critique and artmaking with an expression of the boundary between art and non-art realms as porous. In directing the impulse to disrupt norms beyond the boundaries of art into radical progressive politics,[15] Beuys pushed the symbolic into non-symbolic modes, the artist into non-arts roles, and art into non-art spheres.

Broadly speaking, *social sculpture* advocated for agency, defiance of definitional boundaries, and global impact imperatives articulated within our creation, ambivalence, reform, tool, and medium categories. This (in hindsight perilous) diminishing of boundaries through deregulation of art—Beuys's "total work of art" was artwork that is all-encompassing—paved the way for the total work of neoliberalism to enter into the arts, a condition against which the arts literature surveyed often rails. Zimmerman (2017) identifies how the neoliberal entrepreneur appropriated the mantle of avant-gardism, previously worn by artists:

> the entrepreneur must think himself into the model of the most advanced artistic genius, at the moment when the avant-gardist strategy of innovation at any price becomes the paradigm of dominant economic practice.. .the artistic avant-garde necessarily loses its difference, its marginality, its deviance-value (p. 63).

Dissent and marginality offer degrees of agency that attract both artists and entrepreneurs; at the same time, they pose to each other an existential concern. The loss of distinctiveness Zimmerman describes can occur when liminal spaces are no longer peripheral because the relevant boundaries have shifted. What does this mean for the broader arts entrepreneurship scholarship at the explicit intersection of the two fields? The tension outlined by Essig and Beckman in their 2012

[14] This impulse toward collective, collaborative, and contra-capitalist action is found elsewhere in the arts literature at the respective intersections of entrepreneurship and punk (Goshert 2000; Faris 2004; Nehring 2007), indie cinema (Newman 2009), and digital piracy (Fox 2004; Bishop 2005; McLoed 2005; Black et al. 2007).

[15] In 1978 Beuys published a manifesto based on "the ideals set forth by his previous projects dedicated to direct democracy and education reform, and [insisting] that all Europeans demand a radical alternative to Western capitalism and Eastern communism. He further outlines the ways in which money and the state had caused a state of crisis in the postwar era: the threat of nuclear war, the destruction of the environment, consumer culture, overproduction of goods, and an inequality produced by state-control of the economy." (Jordan 2016)

conversation may not just be difficult to fully resolve, a complete resolution between legitimacy and inclusiveness may in fact be inadvisable. An overly porous definition of arts entrepreneurship risks becoming so inclusive it encompasses everything and becomes meaningless. Clearly not all "creative" or "artistic" commercial activity should be considered central to arts entrepreneurship. Nor should every novel or profitable approach to arts be considered sufficiently entrepreneurial that it is considered central to arts entrepreneurship. But at the same time, too narrow a definition risks excluding meaningful dissent—and as we have shown above, one implicit conceptualization is that there is value in fostering productive deviance in both art and entrepreneurship. This is a space arts entrepreneurship is uniquely situated to explore, specifically because it is a field of study that relies on making explicit and ascribing meaning to both this tension and the processes it represents. Research suggests a positive relationship between moderate levels of rule-breaking behavior and engagement in productive entrepreneurial behavior (Zhang and Arvey 2009). Future organization-level research in arts entrepreneurship could build on this observation to explore, for example, how optimal levels of this productive (or sometimes unproductive) deviance can be facilitated or tolerated within entrepreneurial organizations. Or at the individual level, researchers could investigate how individual artists/entrepreneurs navigate these liminal spaces and explore their contrarian theories and objectives (Felin et al. 2020) while operating within commercial or social structures that necessitate a certain amount of conformity.

If scholars within the arts entrepreneurship field develop a deliberate focus on disruptive and generative platforms for dissent, so-called productive deviance, they would find support for this trajectory in both the arts and entrepreneurship literature. Such a focus would help to smooth over the internal tensions between hegemony and pluralism, and would encourage dissent, perhaps preserving the tendency toward boundary-spanning without dissolving boundaries altogether.

### 4.3 Limitations and additional future research directions

Like any research study, ours has limitations, some of which suggest directions for future research. Our paper's sample of journals included different countries of publication, and the underlying articles reflect the work of scholars from many different countries. Future research could build on our work by taking an explicitly international comparative perspective to examine how differences in scholars' country of residence affect the prevalence and types of implicit perspectives related to arts entrepreneurship. For example, scholars could explore whether French and British entrepreneurship scholars differ in their approach to using art as a tool.

Similarly, although we examined the implicit arts entrepreneurship literature across a specific 20-year window, we did not (but future research could) examine whether there are trends in the relative prevalence of different implicit perspectives on arts entrepreneurship over time. Or whether there are differences in the specific frequency of arts disciplinary focus within entrepreneurship (does entrepreneurship look more commonly to visual or performing arts?), as well as potential for arts disciplinary differences in the assumptions about entrepreneurship (do different arts disciplines take drastically different approaches to their treatment of entrepreneurship?). Lastly, our investigation of arts scholarship was focused primarily on the visual and performing arts, but future work could productively explore the implicit conceptualization of entrepreneurship in other areas such as crafts or creative writing.

## 5 Conclusion

This study uses a structured search and narrative review methodology to shed light on how a set of relevant conversations at the boundaries of arts and entrepreneurship might inform the explicit development of the arts entrepreneurship field. In our discussion, we expound on several of these potential contributions and outline future research possibilities. Of course, we do not intend for our suggestions to be interpreted as exhaustive. Rather, we offer them only to stimulate thought and discussion on the past, present, and future of arts entrepreneurship research. We encourage arts entrepreneurship scholars as well as traditional arts or entrepreneurship scholars approaching the overlap from a more liminal space to think carefully about these opportunities as they seek to move research and practice in new and meaningful directions.

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